

Going through the form

A. LOOK

5 min

The Census form has 65 questions and 26 pages. You do not answer all of them.

Pages 3–5	Who is in the house — Questions 2 to 12
Pages 6–13	Each person: address, country, language, health — Questions 13 to 29
Pages 14–21	Each person: school, work, travel — Questions 30 to 51
Pages 22–23	Each person: unpaid work and care — Questions 52 to 57
Page 24	People who were away — Questions 58 and 59
Page 25	The home itself — Questions 60 to 65

Census Household Form, pages 3–25

Open the form. Find the six columns: Person 1, Person 2, Person 3... Each person has their own column. Every question is asked six times.

B. WORDS

12 min

WORD	MEANING	MY LANGUAGE
question number	a do not answer this question — jump forward	
column	b the number at the start of each question: 1, 2, 3...	
Go to 19	c you can choose — you do not have to answer	
mark one box	d the tall part of the page for one person	
mark all that apply	e choose one answer only	
specify	f choose every answer that is true	
optional	g write the answer in your own words	
leave blank	h write nothing here	

Write the letter of the meaning. Write your own language in the last column.

C. UNDERSTAND

10 min

Find it fast. Use the form. Write the question number.

- a Which language do you use at home?

b How did you get to work?

c How many bedrooms?

d Which country were you born in?

e What is your religion?

f How many cars?
-

THREE QUESTIONS YOU DO NOT HAVE TO ANSWER

Question 24 — religion. The form says **OPTIONAL**. You can leave it blank.

Question 9 — gender and Question 57 — sexual orientation both have a box that says **Prefer not to answer**. They are for people aged 16 and over.

Every other question should be answered. If a question is difficult, call 1800 181 227 — do not guess.

HANDOUT 5 · PAGE 2

18 min

Question 17: you were born in Australia	Go to question _____
Question 21: you speak English only at home	Go to question _____
Question 30: you are not at school	Go to question _____
Question 38: you did not have a job last week	Go to question _____
Question 58: no one was away	Go to question _____

a	Question 11 — marital status	_____
b	Question 23 — ancestry	_____
c	Question 29 — long-term health conditions	_____
d	Question 48 — how you got to work	_____
e	Question 62 — is this home owned or rented?	_____

Q6 First name	tomas
Q7 Date of birth	14 / 06 / 1997 Age: 45
Q17 Country of birth	Brazil — and Q18 left blank
Q22 How well do you speak English?	Well

12 min

[illegible]

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☐ Child of Person 1 ☐ Unrelated flatmate or co-tenant ☐ Other (specify)

[illegible]

☐ No, English only ☐ Yes, other language (specify) _____

☐ Very well ☐ Well ☐ Not well ☐ Not at all

Check your work: ☐ CAPITAL letters ☐ one box only ☐ nothing left blank by mistake

EXIT TICKET
Three words I can use now:
One thing I still need help with:

Census help line 1800 181 227
Interpreter — TIS National 131 450
Online help census.abs.gov.au/help
Could you say that again, please?
Could you explain that in easier English?
I need an interpreter who speaks

Going through the form

Try the exercises first, then check. Mark your own work. Every answer here has a short reason and a longer one — read the short one first.

B. WORDS

	ANSWER	WHY — SIMPLE	WHY — IN DETAIL
1 question number	b	The number at the start.	Questions run 1 to 65. Use the number to find your place, and to ask for help: <i>I don't understand Question 23.</i>
2 column	d	The tall part for one person.	Each page has columns for Person 1 to Person 6. Every question is asked once for each person.
3 Go to 19	a	Skip forward.	A skip instruction. Those questions do not apply to the answer you gave, so you jump past them.
4 mark one box	e	One answer only.	Most questions want a single answer — for example marital status. Two marks make it unusable.
5 mark all that apply	f	Every true answer.	Some questions expect several marks — for example travel to work, if you used a train and a bus.
6 specify	g	Write it yourself.	Used with 'Other'. Your answer is not in the list, so write it in the boxes in capitals.
7 optional	c	You can choose.	Only Question 24, religion, is marked OPTIONAL on this form. You may leave it blank.
8 leave blank	h	Write nothing.	For questions that are not for you — for example a child under 15, or a question about a job you do not have.

C. UNDERSTAND

	ANSWER	WHY — SIMPLE	WHY — IN DETAIL
a Language at home	21	Page 8.	Question 21 asks if you use a language other than English at home. Question 22 then asks how well you speak English.
b How you got to work	48	Page 20.	Question 48 asks about Tuesday 11 August specifically — the same day as Census night.
c How many bedrooms	61	Page 25.	The last page. Questions 60 to 65 are about the home, not about a person.
d Country of birth	17	Page 8.	If you answer Australia, the form sends you to Question 19 and you skip the arrival year.
e Religion	24	Page 10.	The only question on the form marked OPTIONAL.
f How many cars	60	Page 25.	It asks about vehicles parked at or near the home on Census night. Motorbikes are excluded.

Going through the form

THE THREE QUESTIONS YOU DO NOT HAVE TO ANSWER

	ANSWER	WHY — SIMPLE	WHY — IN DETAIL
Q24 religion	Optional	The form says so.	Question 24 is printed with 'Answering this question is OPTIONAL'. Leaving it blank is a normal, complete answer.
Q9 gender	Prefer not to answer	There is a box for it.	For people aged 16 and over. If you do not want to answer, mark 'Prefer not to answer' — that is a real answer, not a blank.
Q57 sexual orientation	Prefer not to answer	There is a box for it.	Also for people aged 16 and over, and it has the same 'Prefer not to answer' box.
Everything else	Answer it	Call, do not guess.	If a question is hard because your situation is unusual, call 1800 181 227, or 131 450 for an interpreter. A guess makes the count wrong.

D. PRACTISE — 1. FOLLOW THE ARROW

	ANSWER	WHY — SIMPLE	WHY — IN DETAIL
Q17 born in Australia	Go to 19	You skip Question 18.	Question 18 asks the year you first arrived in Australia. If you were born here, there is no arrival year.
Q21 English only	Go to 23	You skip Question 22.	Question 22 asks how well you speak English. If English is your only language at home, the question does not apply.
Q30 not at school	Go to 32	You skip Question 31.	Question 31 asks what type of school. If you are not attending one, there is nothing to name.
Q38 no job last week	Go to 50	You skip the whole work section.	Questions 39 to 49 are all about a job. Question 50 asks whether you looked for work, which does apply.
Q58 no one away	Go to 60	You skip Question 59.	Question 59 asks for the details of each person away. With nobody away, you go straight to the questions about the home.

D. PRACTISE — 2. ONE BOX OR ALL THE BOXES?

	ANSWER	WHY — SIMPLE	WHY — IN DETAIL
a Q11 marital status	1	You have one status.	Married, never married, widowed, divorced, or separated — only one can be true at a time.
b Q23 ancestry	ALL	Up to four.	The form allows up to four ancestries, because many people have more than one family background.
c Q29 health conditions	ALL	You can have several.	The question lists conditions a doctor or nurse has told you about. Mark every one that applies.
d Q48 travel to work	ALL	One trip, several vehicles.	The form says: if you used more than one method of travel, mark all that apply. A train and then a bus is two marks.
e Q62 owned or rented	1	A home is one or the other.	Owned outright, owned with a mortgage, rented, and so on — only one describes the home.

Going through the form

D. PRACTISE — 3. FIND THE MISTAKES

	ANSWER	WHY — SIMPLE	WHY — IN DETAIL
tomas	Small letters	Must be CAPITALS.	It should be TOMAS. The whole form is filled in with capital letters.
Age 45	Does not match the date of birth	1997 means he is 29.	The date of birth says 14 June 1997. In August 2026 that person is 29, not 45. Question 7 asks for both, and they must agree.
Q18 blank	Should have his arrival year	He was not born in Australia.	Question 17 says Brazil, so the form does not send you to Question 19. Question 18 asks the year he first arrived to live for a year or more.
Q22 Well	Correct — not a mistake	Nothing wrong here.	There are exactly three mistakes. If you circled this one, check the other rows again.

E. DO IT — TOMAS SILVA

	ANSWER	WHY — SIMPLE	WHY — IN DETAIL
Q6 name	TOMAS · SILVA	First name and family name, separately.	Two different boxes. Capitals, one letter per box.
Q7 age	29	Two boxes.	Born 1997, so 29 in August 2026. If you know the date of birth, write that too.
Q10 relationship	Unrelated flatmate or co-tenant of Person 1	He is a boarder.	He pays to live there and is not related to Amal. This is the box for a boarder — not 'Other relationship'.
Q17 country of birth	Other (specify) — BRAZIL	Brazil is not in the list.	The list has only the six most common countries. Everything else uses 'Other (specify)' and you write it in the boxes.
Q18 year of arrival	2019	Four boxes, four numbers.	Because he was born outside Australia, this question applies to him.
Q21 language	Yes, other language (specify) — PORTUGUESE	Portuguese is not in the list.	The listed languages are the six most common. Portuguese goes in 'Yes, other language (specify)'.
Q22 English	Well	Not 'Very well'.	The four choices are Very well, Well, Not well, Not at all. Because he answered 'Yes' at Question 21, this question applies.

Getting help, and being ready

A. LOOK

4 min

Need help to complete your Census?

We are here to help. Go to www.census.abs.gov.au/help for frequently asked questions, self-service options and information about getting help in person. You can also call us on **1800 181 227**.

Language support. To access in-language support, you can contact the Translating and Interpreting Service (TIS National) on **131 450**.

National Relay Service. If you are deaf, hard of hearing and/or have a speech or communication difficulty, you can contact us through the National Relay Service.

Census Household Form, page 26

B. WORDS

12 min

WORD	MEANING	MY LANGUAGE
help line	_____ a on the internet	
interpreter	_____ b a person who changes your language into English	
Census number	_____ c send your finished form to the ABS	
temporary password	_____ d a telephone number to call for help	
online	_____ e the Census on paper, in an envelope	
paper form	_____ f nobody lives here / nobody is here	
unoccupied	_____ g the number on the front of your form	
submit	_____ h a short password, to use one time	

Write the letter of the meaning. Write your own language in the last column.

C. UNDERSTAND

10 min

What should they do? Match the problem to the answer.

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1 There are eight people in the house. | a Call 1800 181 227 and ask for another form or another Census number. |
| 2 Nobody will be home on Census night. | b Call TIS National on 131 450. |
| 3 My sister wants her own private form. | c Do the Census online, or call 1800 130 250 for an extra paper form. |
| 4 I don't understand the English. | d Go to census.abs.gov.au/help or call 1800 181 227 to tell them. |
| 5 I did the Census online. What about the paper form? | e Recycle it. |

Answers: _____

D. PRACTISE

20 min

USEFUL SENTENCES

Hello. I need some help with my Census form.
I need an interpreter who speaks _____.
Could you say that again, please? Could you explain that in easier English?
Could you show me where to write the answer?
Do I mark one box, or all the boxes? Is this question compulsory or optional?
Let me check that I understood. You said _____.
Thank you. That's all I need.

Role-play. Student A calls the help line. Student B answers. Do it three times, with three different partners. Each time, use fewer notes.

A — YOU ARE CALLING	B — YOU WORK AT THE HELP LINE
1. Nine people in your house on Census night.	Do it online, or call 1800 130 250 for an extra form.
2. You do not understand the English.	TIS National, 131 450.
3. You will be away; the house will be empty.	census.abs.gov.au/help, or call 1800 181 227.

↓ **More support:** read the sentences from the box. ↑ **More challenge:** close the handout. Student B asks one extra question that is not on the card.

E. DO IT — MY CENSUS PLAN

10 min

This is your plan for next week. Tick each one when it is true. **Take this page home.**

Before Tuesday

- ☐ I know Census night is **Tuesday 11 August 2026**.
- ☐ I have my Census form, or my Census number and password for online.
- ☐ I know who will sleep in my home on Tuesday night.
- ☐ I have a blue or black pen.
- ☐ If I need an interpreter, I know to call **131 450**.

On Tuesday night and after

- ☐ I count **everyone** who sleeps in my home — family, babies, visitors.
- ☐ I write in **CAPITAL letters**, one letter in one box.
- ☐ I answer for every person, in their own column.
- ☐ I do the Census **online**, or post the paper form in the Reply Paid envelope.
- ☐ If I do it online, I recycle the paper form.
- ☐ If I am not sure about something, I call **1800 181 227**. I do not guess.

✂ F. TAKE HOME

EXIT TICKET

Three words I can use now:

One thing I still need help with:

GETTING HELP

Census help line 1800 181 227
Interpreter — TIS National 131 450
Online help census.abs.gov.au/help
Could you say that again, please?
Could you explain that in easier English?
I need an interpreter who speaks _____.

Getting help, and being ready

Try the exercises first, then check. Mark your own work. Every answer here has a short reason and a longer one — read the short one first.

B. WORDS

	ANSWER	WHY — SIMPLE	WHY — IN DETAIL
1 help line	d	A number to call.	1800 181 227. It is free from an Australian landline, and the people there are there to help you.
2 interpreter	b	Turns your language into English.	Call TIS National on 131 450, say your language, and they connect you with the ABS through an interpreter.
3 Census number	g	The number on your form.	Printed on the front page. You need it to do the Census online, and to ask for a replacement form.
4 temporary password	h	A one-time password.	It comes with the Census number and is used once, to open your online form.
5 online	a	On the internet.	census.abs.gov.au. The online form does the skip instructions for you, which is why the ABS recommends it.
6 paper form	e	The Census on paper.	This one. When it is finished, post it in the Reply Paid envelope — the postage is already paid.
7 unoccupied	f	Nobody is here.	Used when a home is empty on Census night. Tell the ABS so they do not keep contacting you.
8 submit	c	Send it in.	Online, you press submit. On paper, you post it. Either way, the Census is not done until it is sent.

C. UNDERSTAND

	ANSWER	WHY — SIMPLE	WHY — IN DETAIL
1 Eight people in the house	c	The form has room for six.	Do the Census online, where there is no limit — or call the automated service on 1800 130 250 for an extra paper form. You need the Census number from the front.
2 Nobody home on Census night	d	Tell the ABS.	Go to census.abs.gov.au/help or call 1800 181 227 to say the address is unoccupied. This stops reminder letters and visits.
3 My sister wants a private form	a	Anyone can have their own.	Call 1800 181 227 and ask for an extra form, or another Census number to complete online. Nobody has to show their answers to the rest of the household.
4 I don't understand the English	b	Ask for an interpreter.	TIS National, 131 450. Say the name of your language and wait — the interpreter service is free for this.
5 I did it online — what about the paper?	e	Recycle it.	Page 26 says so. Do not post it as well, or your household could be counted twice.

Getting help, and being ready

D. PRACTISE — THE ROLE-PLAY

	ANSWER	WHY — SIMPLE	WHY — IN DETAIL
Call 1	Online, or 1800 130 250	Nine people, six columns.	Either answer is right. Online has no limit; the automated paper-form line is open 24 hours and needs your Census number.
Call 2	TIS National, 131 450	Ask for your language.	The useful sentence is <i>I need an interpreter who speaks _____</i> . Say the language first — that is all they need to connect you.
Call 3	census.abs.gov.au/help, or 1800 181 227	Tell them the house is empty.	An empty home is not a problem, but the ABS needs to know. Saying nothing means reminder letters and a doorknock.
All three	No single right wording	Listen for the phrases.	The three that matter: <i>I need an interpreter who speaks _____</i> , <i>Could you explain that in easier English?</i> , and <i>Let me check that I understood</i> .

E. DO IT — MY CENSUS PLAN

	ANSWER	WHY — SIMPLE	WHY — IN DETAIL
The checklist	Your own answers	Tick what is already true.	Anything not ticked is what you do between now and Tuesday night. Keep the page — the phone numbers are on it.
The one rule	Call, do not guess	1800 181 227.	A wrong answer counts your household wrongly. Asking is free, it is confidential, and it is what the number is for.

My Census Plan — Tuesday 11 August 2026

BEFORE TUESDAY

- ☐ **Census night is Tuesday 11 August 2026.**
- ☐ I have my Census form — or my **Census number** and **password** to do it online.
- ☐ I know who will **sleep** in my home on Tuesday night.
- ☐ I have a **blue or black pen**.
- ☐ More than six people in the house? I do it online, or call **1800 130 250** for another form.
- ☐ Nobody home on Tuesday? I tell the ABS: **census.abs.gov.au/help** or **1800 181 227**.

ON TUESDAY NIGHT

- ☐ I count **everyone** who sleeps here — family, babies, visitors, boarders.
- ☐ I do **not** count people who came to visit and went home.
- ☐ I count someone who lives here, worked all night, and came home on Wednesday.
- ☐ People who live here but slept somewhere else go in **Questions 58 and 59**.

FILLING IT IN

- ☐ **CAPITAL LETTERS.** One letter in one box. A space between words.
- ☐ Each person has their **own column**. Person 1 is the householder.
- ☐ I follow the arrows: **Go to 19** means skip forward.
- ☐ Question 24 (religion) is **optional**. I can leave it blank.
- ☐ If I make a mistake, I draw a line through the box.

FINISHING

- ☐ I do it **online** at census.abs.gov.au — or post the paper form in the Reply Paid envelope.
- ☐ If I do it online, I **recycle** the paper form.
- ☐ If I am not sure, I **call** — I do not guess.

NUMBERS TO KEEP

Census help 1800 181 227

Interpreter — TIS National 131 450

Extra paper form 1800 130 250

Deaf, hard of hearing, or a speech or communication difficulty? Contact the ABS through the **National Relay Service**.